

To Stream Or Not To Stream, That Is The Question

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Abstract

Netflix is built on volume. Up to 2022 its catalogue holds nearly four thousand films from more than seventy countries, led by the United States. Each film tradition has a signature, with India leaning on drama and romance and running a full half hour longer than an American film, Japan reaching for action, and the United States and Britain heavy with documentaries. The ratings tell a cautionary tale for a would-be rival, since the genres that draw the most viewers, thrillers and action, rate among the lowest, while documentaries earn the highest scores and the smallest audiences. Set against HBO, Netflix trades quality for breadth, its median film scoring a full half point lower across every genre. The lesson for an investor is that breadth fills a catalogue but curation earns the ratings.

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What works in streaming, read off Netflix

Netflix is the natural place to learn what a streaming catalogue should look like, and its own slowing growth makes the question timely. Using the IMDb-sourced record of titles up to 2022, this brief reads the platform through the four lenses the team asked for, the countries the films come from, the genres they belong to, the words their descriptions use, and how they rate and how long they run. Where it helps, the HBO catalogue from the earlier question sits alongside as a benchmark. The catalogue runs to 3,759 films and 2,047 shows drawn from 103 countries, and Figure 1 shows how recent and how movie-heavy it is.

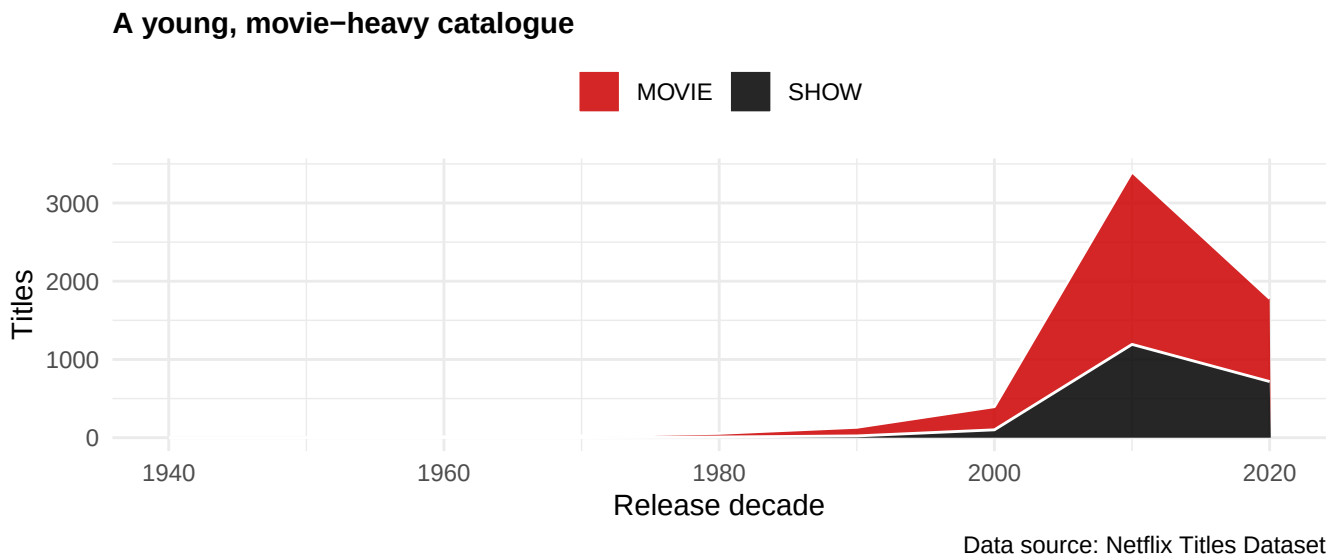
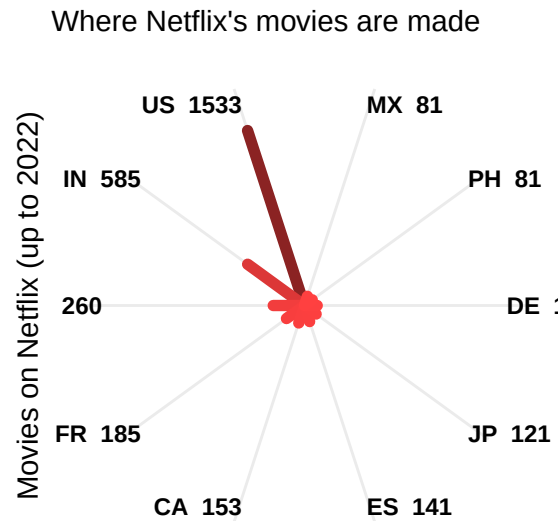


Figure 1: Titles by release decade, films and shows.

Where the movies come from

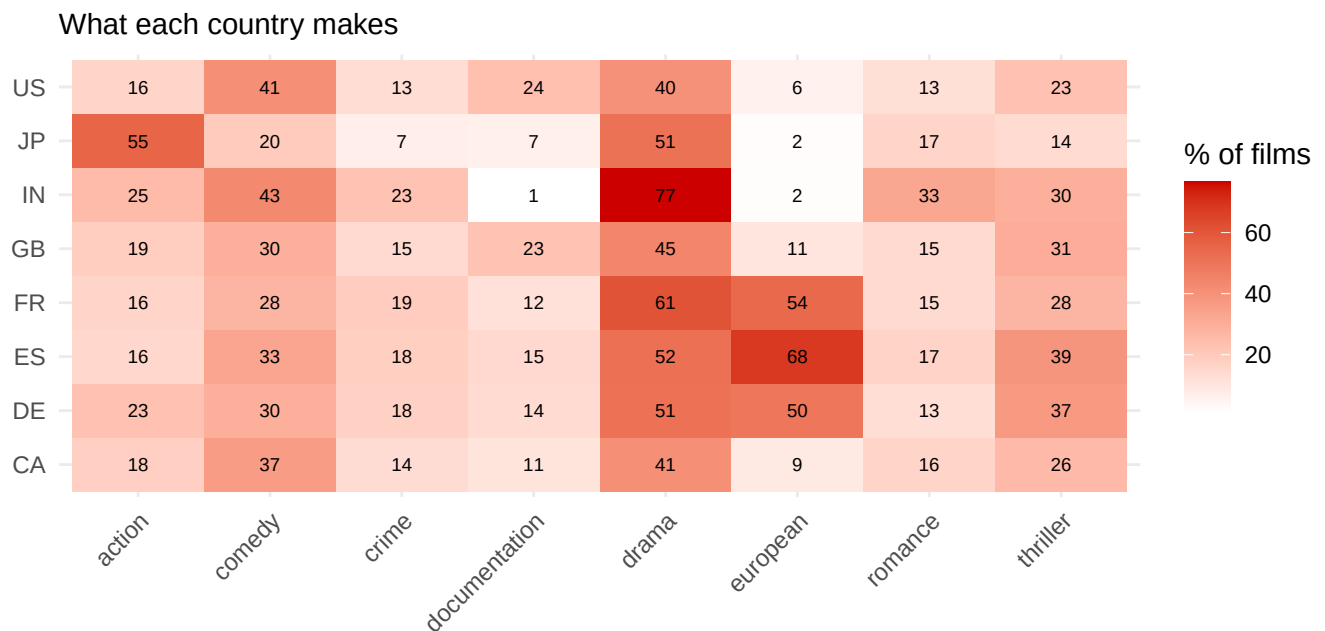
The catalogue is American at its core but far from American alone. Figure 2 ranks the production countries, and the United States leads by a wide margin, with India a clear second ahead of Britain and France. The presence of India this high is the first sign that Netflix is not one catalogue but several national ones stacked together.



Data source: Netflix Titles Dataset

Figure 2: Top production countries among films up to 2022.

Each of those traditions makes something different. Figure 3 reads the share of every major producer's films that carry each genre, and the national signatures are sharp. India leans heavily on drama and romance, the Bollywood template, while Japan is defined by action far more than any other country, and the United States and Britain carry the documentaries. For a rival planning its own slate, the map shows that genre strategy and sourcing country are the same decision.



Data source: Netflix Titles Dataset

Figure 3: Share of each country's films carrying each genre. Films can hold more than one genre.

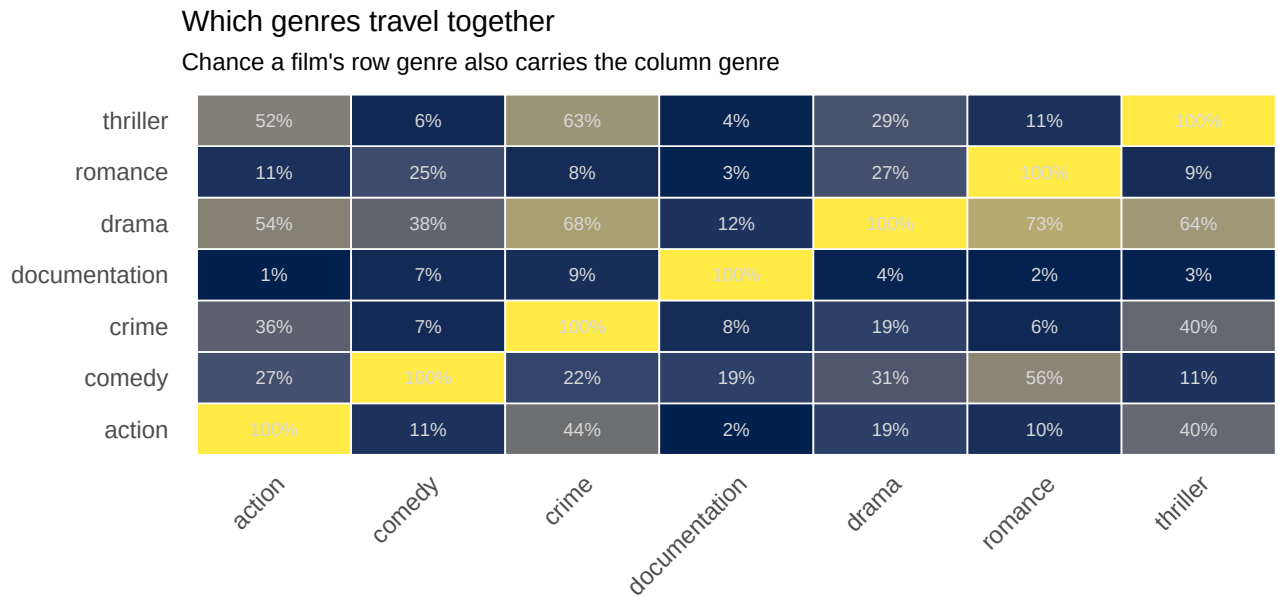
What the descriptions say

The genres are not just labels, they are written in a distinct language. Table 1 reports, for each genre, the words most over-represented in its films’ descriptions against the catalogue as a whole. Thrillers speak of suspects and killers and heists, romances of crushes and weddings, action of assassins and heroes, and documentaries of footage and interviews. The text read confirms the genre map and offers a would-be platform a ready vocabulary for sorting and recommending its own library.

Table 1: Words most distinctive to each genre’s descriptions, by lift against the full catalogue

Genre	Distinctive words
action	naruto, assassin, mankind, lord, policeman, hero
comedy	hilariously, jokes, laughs, parenting, jeff, riffs
crime	serial, heist, criminals, investigation, lord, officers
documentation	documentary, unprecedented, interviews, footage, legacy, intimate
drama	biopic, aftermath, navigates, tensions, tested, ailing
romance	romantic, handsome, crush, romance, chef, marry
thriller	suspects, thriller, investigating, kills, heist, killers

Genres are not worn one at a time, and how they combine says as much as how often they appear. Figure 4 reads each cell as the chance that a film carrying the row genre also carries the column genre, with the diagonal fixed at one by construction. Drama is the clear hub, since close to three in four romances and roughly two in three crime and thriller films are also tagged drama, so a catalogue built on drama quietly underwrites most of the other genres rather than competing with them.



Data source: Netflix Movies Dataset

Figure 4: Conditional genre co-occurrence across films.

Acclaim and popularity pull apart

The most useful finding for an investor is that the crowd and the critics want different things. Figure 5 places each genre by its median score against its median votes, and the two run in opposite directions. Thrillers and action draw the largest audiences yet sit near the bottom for rating, while documentaries earn the highest scores, near 7.1, on the smallest audiences. A thriller pulls a median 9,264 votes against a documentary's 1,487, so a catalogue chasing both prestige and reach needs both kinds of title and should not expect one to deliver the other.

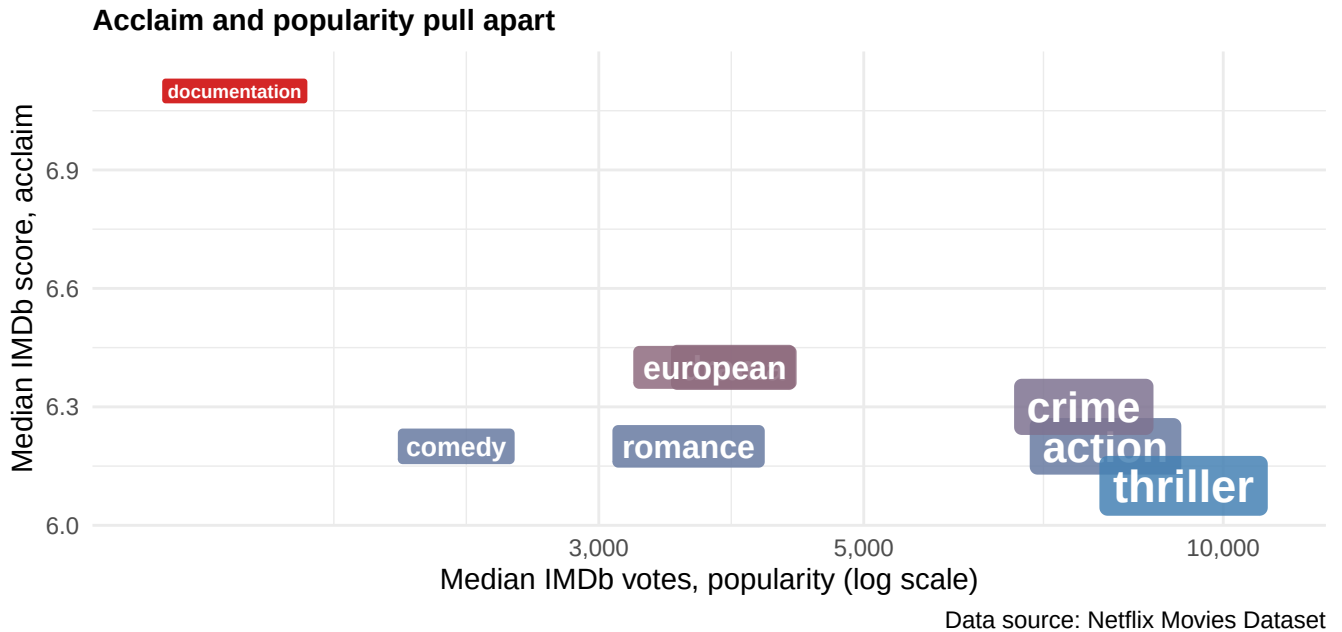


Figure 5: Median IMDb score against median votes, by genre.

The genre medians hide what individual films do. Figure 6 bins every film by its score and its audience, with a fitted line through the cloud. At the film level the tilt is gently positive, with a correlation near 0.21 between score and log votes, so a more-watched film tends to rate a little higher even though the genre medians pull the other way. The contrast is a useful caution, since the divergence the team should plan around lives at the level of genre strategy, not within any single title.

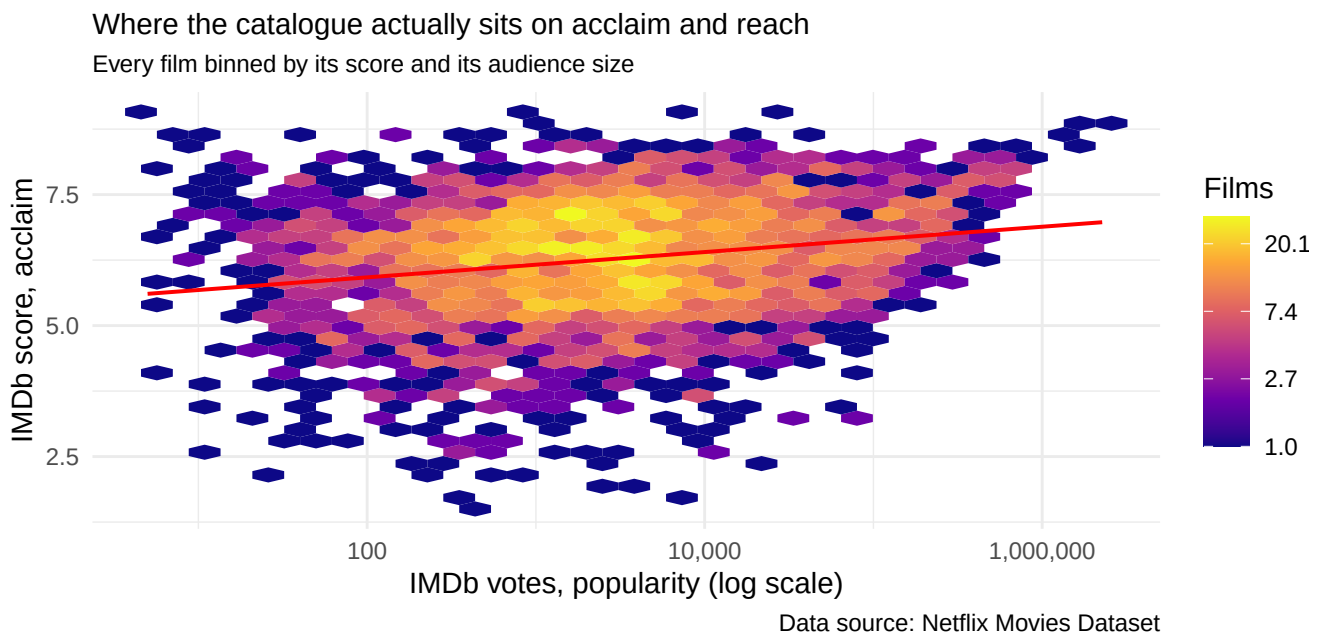


Figure 6: Film density across IMDb score and votes, with a fitted line.

How long the movies run

Length is another place where the national traditions diverge. Figure 7 shows the median runtime by country, and India stands apart at 134 minutes against an American median of 93, a difference of more than half an hour that reflects the song-and-interval format of Bollywood cinema. For a platform deciding how to fill a slate, runtime is not a neutral choice but a fingerprint of where a film was made.

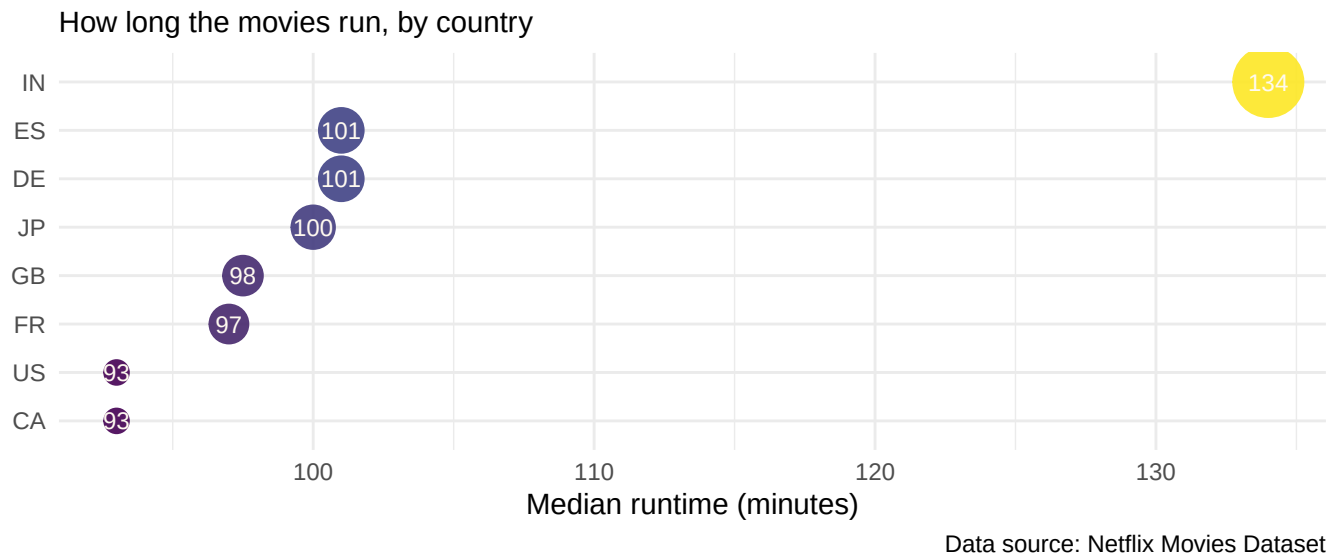


Figure 7: Median film runtime by country.

The median runtimes earlier hint at a difference that the full distributions make vivid. Figure 8 draws the runtime distribution for each major producer as a ridge, ordered by the typical length. The Indian films sit visibly to the right of the American ones rather than merely averaging higher, so the longer film is the rule across that tradition and not the work of a few outliers, which is a real production fact a new entrant would have to budget and schedule around.

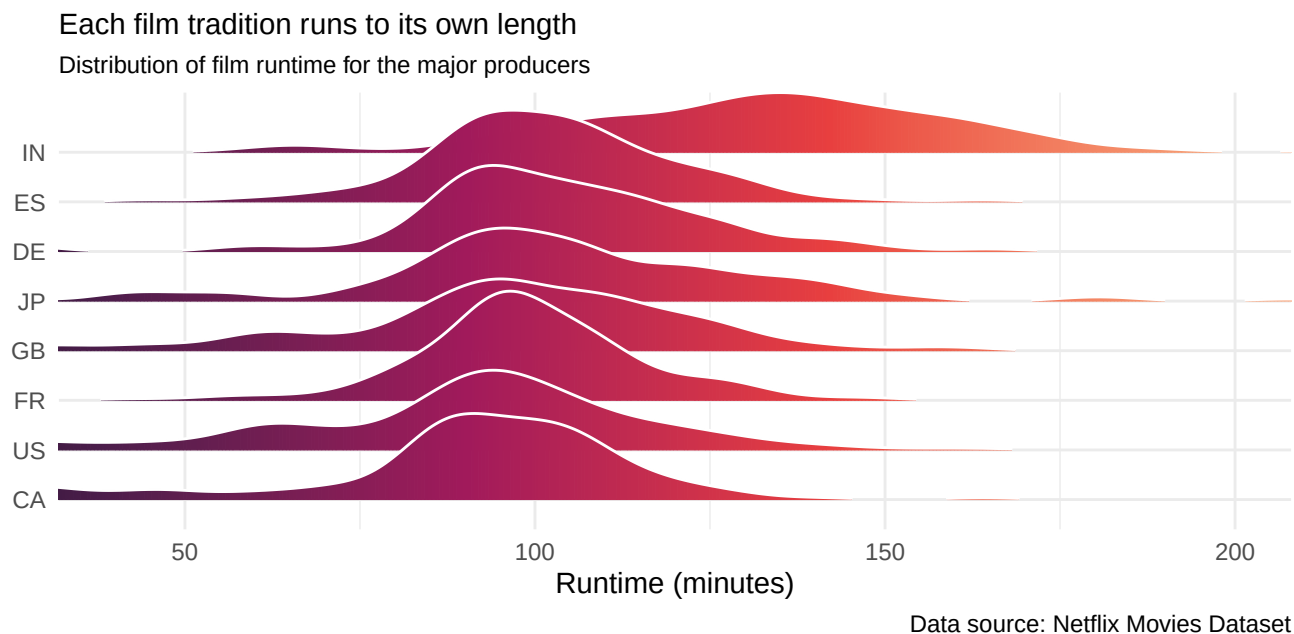


Figure 8: Runtime distribution by major producing country.

Netflix set against HBO

A benchmark sharpens the picture, and HBO is the obvious one. Figure 9 compares the median score of each genre's films across the two platforms, and HBO sits higher in every single genre. The gap is not small, with the typical Netflix film scoring 6.4 against HBO's 6.9, a full half point on the median. Netflix has chosen breadth and HBO has chosen curation, and the ratings reward the curator. The clearest single lesson for the team is that a smaller, better-chosen catalogue rates higher than a larger one.

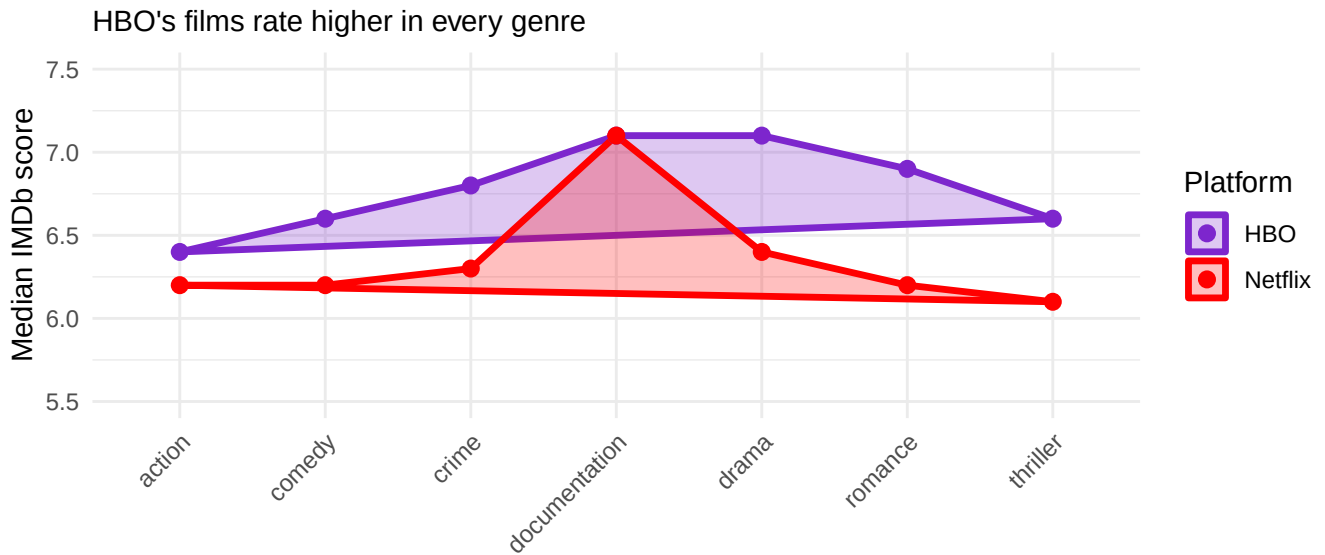


Figure 9: Median IMDb score per genre, Netflix against HBO films.

Who and what fills the shelves

The people behind the films tell the same story as the map. Table 2 lists the actors credited on the most Netflix films, and the list is dominated by Bollywood, led by Shah Rukh Khan with 30 films, which is why India ranks so high. The catalogue also skews mature. Among the films in the classic export, the single most common age rating is TV-MA, so adult-oriented content, not family fare, is the platform's centre of gravity. A new entrant should know that the volume strategy leans on a few prolific national industries and on mature content to fill the long tail.

Table 2: Actors credited on the most Netflix films up to 2022

name	Films
Shah Rukh Khan	30
Boman Irani	25
Kareena Kapoor Khan	25
Anupam Kher	24
Paresh Rawal	22
Nawazuddin Siddiqui	20
Priyanka Chopra Jonas	20
Amitabh Bachchan	19

Table 3: Most common age ratings among Netflix films (classic catalogue export)

Age rating	Films
TV-MA	2062
TV-14	1427
R	797
TV-PG	540
PG-13	490
PG	287

The verdict, to stream and how

Read through the four lenses the team asked for, Netflix resolves into one lesson. The platform has chosen volume, holding 3,759 films from 103 countries, and a rival can fill a catalogue the same way, by leaning on a few productive traditions such as the Indian studio system behind Shah Rukh Khan and his 30 films. The harder truth sits in the ratings, where acclaim and reach pull apart, with documentaries scoring highest near 7.1 on the smallest audiences while thrillers draw the largest crowds and rate among the lowest. No genre delivers both, and the HBO benchmark drives it home, since HBO outscores Netflix in every genre on the median, 6.9 against 6.4, a half point bought by curation over scale.

So the answer is to stream, but with intent rather than breadth, a catalogue built from a few strong production bases, planned genre by genre, and weighted toward quality where the team most wants to be judged. That reading carries the limits of its data, since the record runs only to 2022 and its IMDb scores measure reception rather than profit, with demand, licensing cost and subscriber behaviour all left for other evidence to settle. What the catalogue can settle, it does. Breadth fills the shelves, but curation earns the rating, and a new entrant should buy the second even at the cost of the first.